



MASTERMIND INDIA

Spirit of India Special

far without a good quality lens. He needed funds to expand the business. However, banks and financial institutions were wary of lending to Almel despite his detailed business proposal on the fake currency detector. It was at this point, and near desperation, that he came across the Bharatiya Yuva Shakti Trust (BYST), an initiative that helps aspiring entrepreneurs, especially from disadvantaged backgrounds, to build

and BYST," says Almel.

His fake currency detector, unlike the plastic ones being imported, is cast in sheet metal and is fabricated at his own 5,000 sq ft workshop in Pune which he set up in 2006. The ultraviolet lamp and the special lens scan the fibre optic material which is used in currency notes issued by the government, the watermark next to the image of Gandhi and the word Bharat with the silver mark being signs of an original note. These are usually missing in a fake note or are distorted, visible only when the detector is used.

What makes Almel's model more effective is that it can scan 200

end. Almel wants his company to have an exclusive division which will focus on work related to medical instrumentation and on the R&D for developing a cost-effective ventilator. Besides, he now also wants to contribute to society and that does not stop with building a mosque in his area and a small school for children. The innovator regularly absorbs the trainees of an institute run by the Golden Educational Trust in Pune, which provides technical education to school dropouts. He also offers jobs, from fabrication to powder coating of panels, to smaller entrepreneurs.

The next big stop for him is the field of renewable energy where he

THE MACHINE
CAN SCAN 200
NOTES AT A TIME

UNLIKE OTHER FAKE CURRENCY DETECTORS, THIS MODEL IS FITTED WITH AN ULTRAVIOLET LAMP AND A SPECIAL LENS THAT SCAN THE FIBRE OPTIC MATERIAL USED IN INDIAN CURRENCY.



Photographs by YUSUF KHAN

their businesses. Impressed by his desire to succeed, BYST gave Almel a loan of Rs 50,000 and a business mentor to offer advice. It was the parachute he needed to fly.

Almel, who hails from the Bijapur district of Karnataka, started work on an improvised model in which he used a lens to enhance the detection power of the instrument. He completed this by 2001. It was a success and at the end of a year of trial and error, he had a turnover of Rs 1 lakh. "I feel I have been able to achieve all this only because of a lot of support from my mentor, family

notes at a time and is today being grabbed for commercial application by banks, petrol pumps, big markets and even five-star hotels. Though Almel's market is confined to Maharashtra, the 100-150 pieces he makes in a year have helped notch up a turnover of Rs 2.5 crore with which he has ventured into new products that are high on quality and low on price—a nitrogen tyre inflation system that keeps tyres cool and helps in retention of tyre pressure for a longer duration as well as digital display units.

But this is not where his ambitions

plans to manufacture environment-friendly home lighting for rural applications. Almel also wants to develop nitrogen generators for food packaging and laboratories in the automobile and pharmaceutical sectors. With an ISO 9001 certification and a company employing 80 persons, Almel has come a long way from the moment the currency detector idea hit him. The best part is, he's just getting started.

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